

200 YEARS OF BAGS AND PURSES

Before the end of the 18th century women kept their valuables under their skirts in a girdle pouch, or a pocket tied around their waist. By the 1790s, when dresses became slim and columnar, pockets were replaced by reticules (small decorative bags carried in the hand), to avoid spoiling the line of the dress. Since then myriad styles have evolved, from the exquisitely beaded evening bag to the exorbitant designer “It” bag.



1915 Silk clutch embroidered with Oriental design and imitation-jade-encrusted filigree frame

1919 Silver finger-purse engraved with arabesques



1920s Beaded handbag with a filigree frame and a chain strap



17th Century Purse with raised embroidery in coloured silk and metal threads and sequins



1920 Beaded bag of silver and gold beads with diamanté paste decoration



1940s Suedette (fake suede) bag with pleated central panel and brass clasp



1940s Red snakeskin bag with clasp opening and gilt-metal hardware



Early 1950s Lucite handbag in light blue with a clear lid and handle, designed by Charles S. Khan



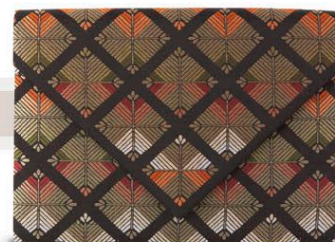
1950s Pleated box purse with a mirror fitted inside, designed by Bienen-Davis



1970s Evening bag of brushed gold over metal, with coral decoration, designed by Judith Leiber



1970s Tote bag of woven cotton with a psychedelic pattern, and leather handles and trim



1980s Envelope clutch designed by Diane Love, with sequins in a trellis design



1980s Chainmail bag by Paco Rabanne, made of black leather and linked aluminum disks